

TAB 14



Board of Education Report

File #: Res-002-24/25, Version: 1

Mr. Schmerelson - Suicide Awareness and Prevention Month (Res-002-24/25) For Action September 10, 2024

Whereas, Suicide is a severe public health crisis that takes an enormous toll on families, students, employees, and communities;

Whereas, In 2021, the Centers for Disease Control (CDC) and Prevention's Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance System (YRBSS) indicated that 42% of high school students in America experience persistent sadness or hopelessness every day for two straight weeks in a row with these numbers being high amongst females (57%), Hispanics (46%), multiracial (49%), and LGBTQ+ (69%);

Whereas, The same report from the CDC's Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance System indicated that 29% of high school students in America experience poor mental health, with these numbers being especially high amongst females (41%) and LGBTQ+ (52%);

Whereas, The same report from the CDC's Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance System indicated that 22% of high school students seriously considered suicide in 2021, with the highest demographic being LGBTQ+ students (45%);

Whereas, Factors such as discrimination, adverse childhood experiences, stigma, familial and community rejection, mental illness, social networks, and other factors that compromise life functioning may result in elevated suicide risk, particularly for vulnerable student populations;

Whereas, In September 2016, Governor Jerry Brown signed Assembly Bill (AB) 2246, now California Education Code 215, that took effect in 2017-18, setting a requirement for all Local Educational Agencies (LEA), including county offices of education, school districts, state special schools and charter schools that serve pupils in grades 7 to 12 to adopt a policy on pupil suicide prevention that specially addresses the needs of high-risk students;

Whereas, In July 2017, Michelle King, Superintendent of Schools, approved the implementation of the annual online Suicide Prevention and Awareness Training for all District staff;

Whereas, Despite the fact that mental illness is treatable and youth suicide is a preventable public health problem, ninety percent of deaths by suicide can be attributed to mental illness;

Whereas, Suicide rates increased by 36% between the years 2000 and 2021, responsible for being the second leading cause of death for people ages 10-14 and 20-34, according to the Centers for Disease Control (CDC);

Whereas, Suicide rates decreased slightly between 2018 and 2019, it was still the 10th leading cause of death in the United States and is the second leading cause of death among children between the ages of 10-14 and 15-24;

Whereas, The phone number of the Suicide and Crisis Hotline has changed to 988, available 24 hours a day, seven days a week;

Whereas, The focus on mental health aligns with the Los Angeles Unified School District's Strategic Plan on Pillar 1B, which focuses on student happiness at their schools, and Pillar 1C, which seeks to eliminate opportunity gaps. Furthermore, this also aligns with Pillars 2A, which establishes welcoming environments, 2B, the whole-child well-being, and 2C, strong social-emotional skills;

Whereas, Children and teens spend a significant amount of their young lives in school, and the personnel who interact with them daily are in a prime position to recognize the warning signs of suicide and make the appropriate referrals for help. School personnel are instrumental in helping students and their families by identifying students at risk and linking them to school and community mental health resources;

Whereas, An analysis of i-STAR incidents reported between 2016 and 2020 found that middle school rates of suicidal behavior and high schools reported the highest rates of substance-related incidents;

Whereas, Suicide prevention involves the collective efforts of families and caregivers, the school community, mental health practitioners, local community organizations, and related professionals to reduce the incidence of suicide through education, awareness, and services;

Whereas, Suicide prevention involves inclusive school-wide activities and programs that enhance a sense of belonging, contribute to a safe and nurturing environment, and strengthen protective factors that reduce the risk for students; and

Whereas, National Suicide Prevention Week will be observed from September 8-14, 2024, to help call public attention to the increasing incidence of suicide and to inform about suicide prevention and warning signs of suicide; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District hereby declares September Suicide Prevention Awareness Month in the Los Angeles Unified School District;

Resolved further, That throughout National Suicide Prevention Month, but especially during National Suicide Prevention Week (September 8-14, 2024), the District will use social media channels and direct communication to District families to raise awareness and promote resources on suicide prevention, especially resources focused on the needs of our most vulnerable students;

Resolved further, That the District will review and update as necessary the resources posted to the District's School Mental Health / Crisis Counseling and Intervention Services website and make sure that the website prominently features the new Suicide and Crisis Hotline Lifeline: 988;

Resolved further, That the Superintendent or his designee report to the Committee of the Whole within 120 days on improvements or progress that has been made on the distribution of mental health resources to all District students during the past year and potential future plans; and, be it finally

Resolved, That by the adoption of this resolution, the Board encourages all students, faculty, administrators, and parents to promote a climate of positive behavior support and intervention; monitor students' emotional state and well-being; and make referrals for crisis support and mental health, as needed.

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